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POWER-SHARING

Civics - Class 10 | Chapter 1 | Deep
Structured NCERT Notes

1. Introduction to Power-Sharing

Meaning of Power-Sharing

Power-sharing is the distribution or decentralization of power among different organs, levels, and groups in a democracy. In a democracy, **all the power does not rest with any one organ, person, or group.** Power is shared to **prevent abuse of power, ensure good governance, and accommodate diversities.**

In a democracy, no single person or group holds all the power. Effective power distribution among the **legislature, executive, and judiciary** is essential for maintaining **democratic balance.** **An intelligent sharing of power among legislature, executive and judiciary is very important to the design of a democracy.**

Power sharing is also central to dividing power among the country's citizens. It ensures that **all sections of society feel included** and **have a voice in decision-making.** **Power sharing ensures harmony among different social and ethnic groups.**

In this chapter and the next two chapters, power-sharing is studied in different forms:

- **Chapter 1:** Power-sharing among different organs, levels, and groups.
- **Chapter 2:** Federalism - power-sharing among different levels of government.
- **Chapter 3:** Democracy and Diversity - power-sharing among different social groups.

2. Why is Power-Sharing Desirable?

Two Main Reasons

There are two main reasons why power-sharing is desirable in a democracy: prudential reason and moral reason. These two reasons explain **why power-sharing is important** and **why it should be practiced in all democracies.**

Prudential reason focuses on **practical benefits** such as stability, peace, and reduced conflict. **Moral reason**

focuses on **democratic values** such as fairness, equality, participation, and justice.

2.1 Prudential Reason

Prudential reason says that power-sharing helps to reduce the possibility of conflict between social groups. This is a **practical reason** because power-sharing is done to produce **better outcomes**.

Social conflict often leads to violence and political instability. When different social groups such as **religious, linguistic, or ethnic communities** fight for power, it can lead to **violence, civil war, and destruction**. **Power-sharing helps prevent this conflict.**

Power-sharing ensures that minority groups also have a say in governance. When minority groups have **representation in government**, they **feel included** and are **less likely to rebel**.

Example from India:

- **Reservation system** provides benefits to **Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST), and Other Backward Classes (OBC)**.
- **Seats are reserved in Parliament and State Assemblies** for SC/ST.

- **This ensures minority and disadvantaged groups have a voice** in governance.
- **This reduces social conflict and promotes harmony.**

Prudential reason says power-sharing will lead to better outcomes. It is **practical** and **strategic** because it helps **avoid conflict** and **ensure stability**.

2.2 Moral Reason

Moral reason says that power-sharing is the very spirit of democracy. This is a **moral reason** because power-sharing is done because it is **inherently right**, not only because of practical benefits.

Power-sharing ensures that people have a say in governance. In a democracy, **people are the rulers**, and **everyone should have a voice** in decision-making. **Power-sharing ensures this democratic ideal.**

Power-sharing promotes fairness and inclusivity. When power is shared, **all groups are treated equally** and **no group is discriminated against**. **Everyone gets a fair chance to participate in governance.**

Example from India:

- **The Constitution grants citizens fundamental rights.**

- **Everyone is treated equally** regardless of caste, religion, gender, or language.
- **Everyone has the right to vote and participate in democracy.**
- **This is the spirit of democracy.**

Moral reason says power-sharing is inherently right. It is **democratic, fair, and just.** **Power-sharing is the essence of democracy itself.**

2.3 Summary of Both Reasons

Prudential reason says power-sharing is **useful** because it reduces conflict and creates political stability. **Moral reason** says power-sharing is **right** because it is part of democratic fairness and people's participation.

Comparison between prudential and moral reasons:

- **Type:** Prudential is a practical reason; moral is an ethical reason.
- **Why power-sharing?** Prudential reduces conflict and leads to better outcomes; moral expresses the spirit of democracy.
- **Focus:** Prudential focuses on stability and harmony; moral focuses on fairness, equality, and democracy.

- **Example:** Reservation can reduce social conflict; fundamental rights ensure equality.
- **Key idea:** Prudential says power-sharing is **useful**; moral says power-sharing is **right**.

Both reasons are important. Prudential reason says power-sharing is **practical and beneficial**. Moral reason says power-sharing is **democratic and just**.

3. Forms of Power-Sharing in Modern Democracies

Four Main Forms

Modern democracies show power-sharing in four different forms. These four forms are **observed in democracies around the world**. Each form represents a different way of sharing power.

The four forms are:

- **Power shared among different organs of government** - horizontal division.
- **Power shared among different levels of government** - vertical division.
- **Power shared among different social groups.**

- **Power shared among political parties, pressure groups, and movements.**

3.1 Power Shared Among Different Organs of Government

Power is shared among different organs of government such as the legislature, executive, and judiciary. This is called **separation of powers or **horizontal division of power**.**

Horizontal means all organs are at the same level. None of these organs is completely superior to the others. **Each organ has different powers and functions, and each organ checks the others.**

The three organs of government are:

1. Legislature:

- **Makes laws.**
- **Debates and passes laws.**
- **Represents people's will.**
- **In India:** Parliament at the centre and Legislative Assemblies in states.

2. Executive:

- **Implements laws.**

- **Takes day-to-day decisions.**
- **Runs the administration.**
- **In India:** Prime Minister and Council of Ministers at the centre; Chief Minister and Ministers in states.

3. Judiciary:

- **Interprets laws.**
- **Resolves disputes.**
- **Can declare laws unconstitutional** if they violate the Constitution.
- **In India:** Supreme Court, High Courts, and District Courts.

Each organ checks the others through checks and balances:

- **Parliament makes laws**, but **Courts can declare them unconstitutional.**
- **Government implements laws**, but **Parliament can question ministers.**
- **Courts interpret laws**, but **judges are appointed through a constitutional process.**

This system ensures that no single organ becomes too powerful. Each organ limits the power of the others, preventing abuse of power.

3.2 Power Shared Among Different Levels of Government

Power is shared among different levels of government - central government and state government. This is called **federalism** or **vertical division of power**.

Vertical means different levels of government. The **central government** works at the national level, **state governments** work at the state level, and **local governments** work at the village or city level.

In India, power is shared among three levels:

1. Central Government or Union Government:

- **Handles national issues.**
- **Examples:** Defence, foreign policy, currency, railways, post office, and atomic energy.
- **Union List** contains subjects mainly handled by the central government.

2. State Governments:

- **Handle state-level issues.**

- **Examples:** Police, agriculture, health, education, trade, and commerce.
- **State List** contains subjects mainly handled by state governments.

3. Local Governments:

- **Handle local-level issues.**
- **Examples:** Water supply, sanitation, roads, street lights, and local markets.
- **Village level:** Panchayats.
- **City level:** Municipalities.

Each level has its own powers defined by the Constitution. Neither level can unilaterally change the powers of the other. The Constitution clearly divides powers between central and state governments.

This system ensures that power is distributed vertically among **central, state, and local governments**, each with **its own sphere of authority**.

3.3 Power Shared Among Different Social Groups

Power is shared among different social groups such as religious and linguistic communities. This form of power-sharing helps **accommodate diversities** and **prevent majority domination**.

This form ensures that minority groups also have representation in government. It makes democracy more **inclusive** and **fair**.

Example: Belgium:

- **Belgium has Dutch-speaking and French-speaking communities.**
- **Community government gives power to different linguistic groups.**
- **Each community has its own government** for matters such as education, culture, and language.
- **This is a unique arrangement in Belgium.**

In India:

- **Reservation system** ensures representation for **Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST), and Other Backward Classes (OBC).**

- **Seats are reserved in Parliament and State Assemblies** for SC/ST.
- **This ensures disadvantaged groups have a voice** in governance.
- **OBC reservation** exists in government jobs and education.

This form of power-sharing ensures that minority and disadvantaged groups are not marginalized. Everyone gets representation regardless of their caste, religion, or language.

3.4 Power Shared Among Political Parties, Pressure Groups, and Movements

Power is shared among different political parties, pressure groups, and movements. This happens through **competition and cooperation** among different political entities.

1. Political Parties:

- **Different political parties compete for power** through elections.
- **Over time, power is shared among different parties** because no single party holds power forever.
- **Coalition governments** are formed when no single party gets majority.

- **Example:** India has multiple political parties such as Congress, BJP, CPI, and regional parties.

2. Pressure Groups:

- **Trade unions, farmer organizations, and business groups influence decisions.**
- **They do not directly hold power but influence those who hold power.**
- **Example:** Trade unions influence labour policies, and farmer organizations influence agricultural policies.
- **They represent specific interests and lobby for their demands.**

3. Movements:

- **Social movements demand change and influence government decisions.**
- **Examples:** Women's movement, environmental movement, and dalit movement.
- **These movements raise awareness and pressure government to act.**

This form of power-sharing ensures that power is not monopolized by one party. Different parties get a chance to rule, and different groups get their concerns addressed.

4. Case Study - Belgium: Successful Example of Power-Sharing

Background of Belgium

Belgium is a small country in Europe, bordering France, Germany, Luxembourg, and the Netherlands. It has a **population of about 11 million** and covers an **area of about 30,000 square kilometers**.

Belgium is divided into different linguistic communities. The **language situation is complex** because of **multiple linguistic groups**.

Linguistic communities in Belgium:

- **Dutch-speaking community:** About **59%** of the population, mainly in the northern region called **Flanders**.
- **French-speaking community:** About **40%** of the population, mainly in the southern region called **Wallonia**.
- **German-speaking community:** About **1%** of the population, mainly in a small eastern area.

Brussels, the capital city, has a different language composition:

- **French-speaking people:** About **80%**.
- **Dutch-speaking people:** About **20%**.
- **This is opposite to the national picture**, where Dutch speakers are the majority nationally.

This created a problem because the **Dutch-speaking majority nationally** was a **minority in Brussels**, while the **French-speaking community was richer and more powerful**.

The Problem in Belgium

The linguistic tension between Dutch-speaking and French-speaking communities created political instability. The **Dutch-speaking community**, though a majority nationally, felt that the **French-speaking community** was dominating the government and capital.

Specific problems:

- **French-speaking community was richer** and had more economic power.
- **French-speaking community dominated Brussels**, where about 80% spoke French.

- **Dutch-speaking community felt discriminated against.**
- **Both communities wanted more power and protection.**

This situation could have led to conflict between the two communities. **Power-sharing was needed** to resolve this tension.

The Solution: Power-Sharing Arrangement

Between 1970 and 1993, Belgium revised its constitution four times to accommodate different linguistic groups. The **current arrangement** is a **successful model of power-sharing**.

The Belgian power-sharing arrangement includes:

1. Equal Representation in Central Government:

- **The number of Dutch-speaking and French-speaking ministers should be equal** in the central government.
- **Some special laws require support from majority of each community.**

- **This prevents one community from dominating** the other.

2. State Government or Regional Governments:

- **State governments are not subordinate to the central government.**
- **States have their own powers**, similar to a federal system.
- **Flanders** manages its own regional matters.
- **Wallonia** manages its own regional matters.

3. Community Government:

- **A third kind of government called community government** exists in Belgium.
- **It is elected by people belonging to one language community** - Dutch, French, or German.
- **It has power over cultural, educational, and language-related issues.**
- **This is unique to Belgium.**

4. Brussels Status:

- **Brussels has a separate government.**
- **Both communities have representation.**

- **Both Dutch-speaking and French-speaking people have equal representation** in Brussels government.

Belgian model is a successful example of power-sharing. It **accommodated diversities** and **prevented conflict** between communities. **Belgium remains united and stable** despite linguistic differences.

5. Case Study - Sri Lanka: Failure of Majoritarianism

Background of Sri Lanka

Sri Lanka is an island nation in South Asia, south of India. It has a **population of about 22 million** and covers an **area of about 65,000 square kilometers**.

Sri Lanka has different ethnic communities. The **ethnic situation is complex** because of **multiple ethnic groups**.

Major ethnic communities in Sri Lanka:

- **Sinhalese:** Speak Sinhala, mostly follow Buddhism, and form about **74%** of the population.
- **Tamils:** Speak Tamil, mostly follow Hinduism or Christianity, and form about **18%** of the population.

- **Muslims:** Speak Tamil or Urdu, follow Islam, and form about **7%** of the population.
- **Others:** Various smaller groups form about **1%**.

Tamils are divided into two groups:

- **Sri Lankan Tamils:** About **13%**, lived in Sri Lanka for generations.
- **Indian Tamils:** About **5%**, brought by British as plantation workers.

Sinhalese are the majority community, while Tamils are the minority community.

Majoritarianism in Sri Lanka

In 1956, an Act was passed to recognize Sinhala as the only official language. This was **majoritarianism** - the **majority community imposing its will on the minority.**

Following measures were taken by the Sinhalese-speaking majority:

1. 1956 - Sinhala Only Act:

- **Sinhala was recognized as the only official language.**
- **Tamil was not recognized as an official language.**

- **Tamils were discriminated against** because government jobs required Sinhala.
- **Tamils felt excluded** from government and administration.

2. Preferential Policy:

- **Government favored Sinhala applicants** for university positions and government jobs.
- **Tamils were discriminated against**, even if they were qualified.
- **Tamils felt that their future was being threatened.**

3. 1972 Constitution:

- **Buddhism was given special status** in the Constitution.
- **Tamils**, many of whom were Hindus or Christians, felt discriminated against.
- **Tamils felt their culture and religion were being marginalized.**

4. Continued Discrimination:

- **Tamils felt that none of these measures guaranteed them equal political rights.**

- **Tamils felt they did not have a fair share in administration.**
- **Tamils felt their language and culture were not respected.**
- **Tamils began demanding more autonomy** for Tamil-speaking areas.

Consequences of Majoritarianism

The demand for Tamil Eelam, a separate state, led to civil war. Tamils demanded **more autonomy** and eventually **a separate state** called **Tamil Eelam**.

Civil War from 1983 to 2009:

- **1983:** Civil war began between the **Sri Lankan government** and **Tamil Tigers (LTTE)**.
- **Tamil Tigers demanded a separate state** for Tamils.
- **Thousands of people were killed** on both sides.
- **Families were displaced** and became refugees.
- **The economy was damaged** because tourism and trade were affected.
- **Sri Lanka became known as a violent and divided country.**

This shows what happens when power is not shared:

- **Majority community dominates.**
- **Minority community suffers.**
- **Conflict and violence increase.**
- **The country becomes unstable.**

Sri Lanka is a warning example. Majoritarianism leads to destruction, while power-sharing is essential to prevent conflict.

6. Comparison - Belgium vs Sri Lanka

Clear Comparison

Belgium followed power-sharing, while Sri Lanka followed majoritarianism. Belgium managed diversity through **constitutional arrangements**, while Sri Lanka tried to impose the will of the majority.

Belgium vs Sri Lanka:

- **Approach:** Belgium used **power-sharing**; Sri Lanka used **majoritarianism**.
- **Outcome:** Belgium remained **united and stable**; Sri Lanka faced **civil war**.

- **Language Policy:** Belgium gave **recognition to linguistic communities**; Sri Lanka made **Sinhala the only official language**.
- **Religion:** Belgium did not impose one religion; Sri Lanka gave **special status to Buddhism**.
- **Government Type:** Belgium used **federal and community government**; Sri Lanka remained more **centralized**.
- **Minority Rights:** Belgium protected minorities; Sri Lanka discriminated against Tamils.
- **Conflict:** Belgium avoided major violent conflict; Sri Lanka faced **civil war from 1983 to 2009**.
- **Lesson:** Belgium shows **power-sharing works**; Sri Lanka shows **majoritarianism fails**.

The lesson is clear: Power-sharing is essential for democracy. Majoritarianism leads to conflict and destruction.

7. NCERT Key Concepts and Definitions

Important Definitions

Power-Sharing: Distribution of power among different organs, levels, and groups in a democracy.

Prudential Reason: Power-sharing reduces conflict and leads to better outcomes.

Moral Reason: Power-sharing is the spirit of democracy; it ensures fairness and inclusivity.

Separation of Powers: Power shared among legislature, executive, and judiciary.

Federalism: Power shared among central and state governments.

Community Government: Power shared among different social or linguistic communities, as in Belgium.

Majoritarianism: Majority community imposing its will on minority, as in Sri Lanka.

Checks and Balances: Each organ of government checks the others to prevent abuse of power.

Horizontal Division: Power shared among organs at the same level, such as legislature, executive, and judiciary.

Vertical Division: Power shared among different levels, such as central, state, and local governments.